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Contact in the Past

*How Contact has
Shaped Language
in Society*



UNIL | Université de Lausanne

Robin Meyer

What to expect ...

- Insights from language contact research – seminal and new!
- Clearly presented with a non-specialist audience in mind
- A free-for-all Q&A session afterwards



Outline

1. Contact as you've seen it
2. What we want to know
3. Alignment change
4. Bilingual interference
5. Spatial evidence & contact
6. The role of agency
7. Summing up

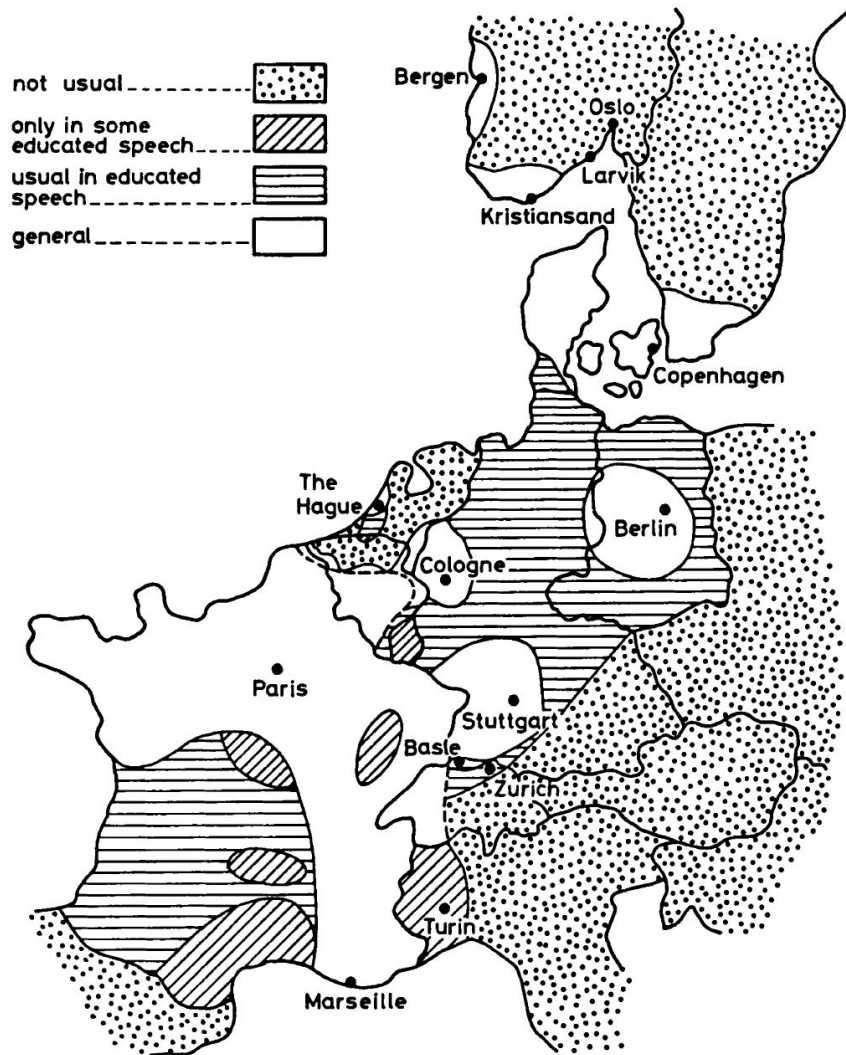


Languages in contact

- It has been suggested that more than 50% of the world can be considered bi/multilingual (e.g. [Ansaldi et al. 2008: 540](#))
- Taking the long view, monolingualism by contrast is a relatively new phenomenon (e.g. [Trudgill 2011](#))
- What happens when languages are in contact?
 - Language-contact research broadly considers the linguistic and the sociocultural mechanisms that can lead to linguistic change
- To begin, we will consider two brief illustrative examples:
 - Diffusion of Metropolitan French /R/ across western Europe ([Trudgill 1974](#))
 - Development of *after perfect* in Irish Englishes ([Ronan 2005](#))

Spread of /R/ in western Europe

- Back dorsal pronunciation of /r/:
 - Generally thought to have emerged in Paris (17th c.) (Martinet 1969)
 - Upper-class prestige feature
 - Reached Copenhagen by 1780.
- Standard in French, German, Danish, ~Dutch, Norwegian, Swedish (and found elsewhere)
- Trudgill (1974) asks how uvular /r/ achieved this distribution:
 - Innovation diffusion through gradual spread
 - Diffusion took the form of jumping of uvular /r/ from one large urban centre to another (The Hague, Cologne, Berlin ...)





“I’m after falling down the stairs.”

“Would you believe, I just fell down the stairs there.”

Irish *after*-perfect

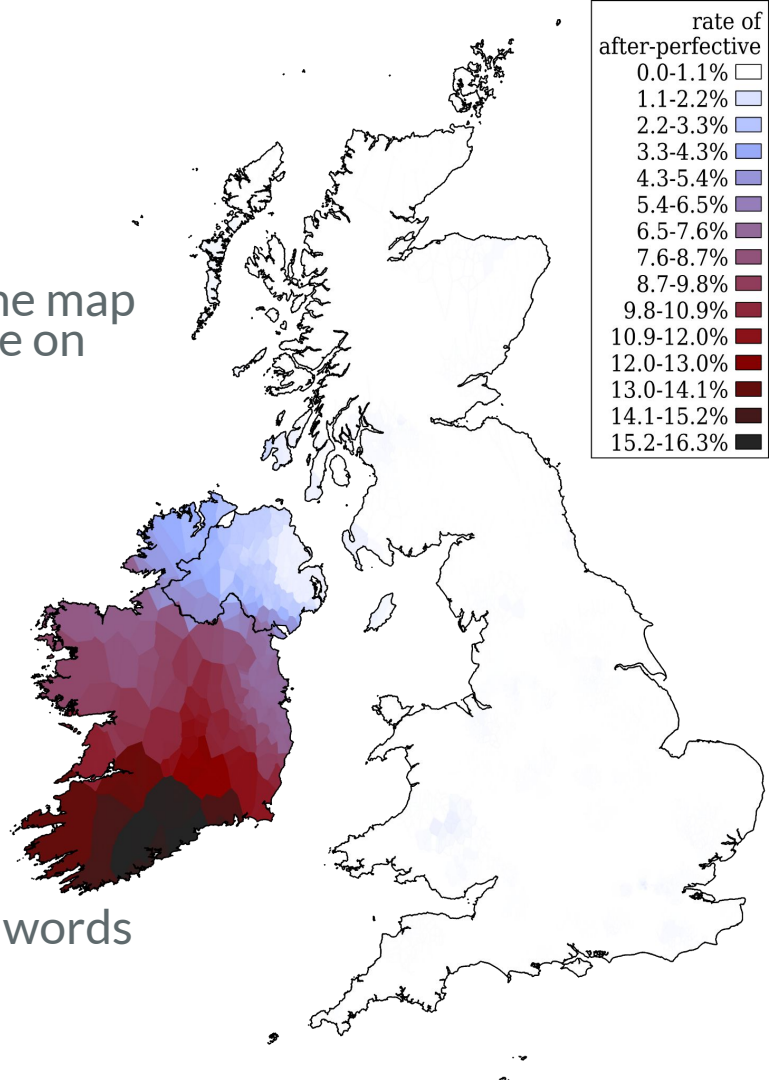
Ronan (2005)

- often recorded as a feature of Irish English - the map (Willis et al. forthcoming) shows the rate of use on Twitter, so we can see this is still restricted to Irish English

- Irish Gaelic has a construction that looks very similar:

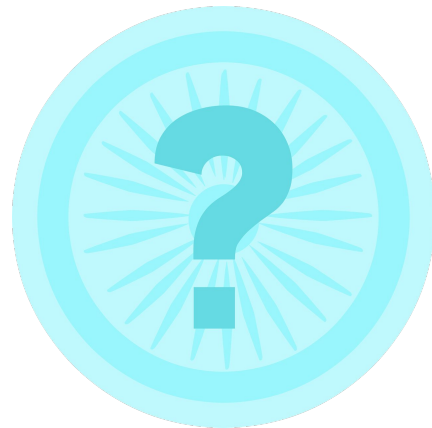
Tá sé tréis leitir a scríobh
“He has written a letter”
literally: “he is after writing a letter”

- the easiest explanation is that is an example of **structural borrowing**: the structure is borrowed from Irish to English, but the actual words used are replaced with existing English words



Research questions

- **What** is language contact (vis-à-vis internal evolution)?
- What **areas** of a language are affected by language contact?
- What **effect** does language contact have on a language?
- **How** do we know it is language contact (and only language contact)?
- What are we interested in about a contact **scenario**?
- **Where** do we find information?



Alignment Change through Contact

Classical Armenian in Contact: Background

- Armenian is an Indo-European language (independent branch)
- heavily influenced by Iranian languages (Parthian, Middle Persian)
- the extent of this influence is still under investigation but includes:
 - lexicon
 - phonology
 - derivational morphology
 - syntax
- Contact lasted $\pm 1,000$ years (incl. Iranian hegemony and direct rule)
 - 66 CE: installation of a Parthian king
 - 224 CE: fall of the Parthian Empire, rise of the Sasanians
 - ~300 CE: Christianisation of Armenia & its rulers
 - 428 CE: imposition of direct Sasanian rule



Hübschmann (1875, 1897); Meillet (1911–12);
Garsoïan (1997a,b); Russell (1997)

Pattern replication in Classical Armenian

Language contact can [...] lead to re-shaping of language-internal structures. [...] In this case] the patterns of distribution, of grammatical and semantic change, and of formal-syntactic arrangement at various levels [...] are modelled on an external source.

(Matras & Sakel 2007:829–30)

- intensifier Armenian *ink'n* “-self” serves as anaphora and (to a lesser extent) as switch-function marker
 - exact parallel in Parthian *xwd* and Middle Persian *wxd* “-self; same”
- reflexive Armenian *anjn iwr* modelled on Parthian *xwyš gryw* “own body/self”
- complementiser Armenian *(e)t'ē* functions also as quotative and indirect statement/question marker
 - exact parallel in Parthian and Middle Persian *kw*
 - rare elsewhere

Morphosyntactic Alignment: Basics

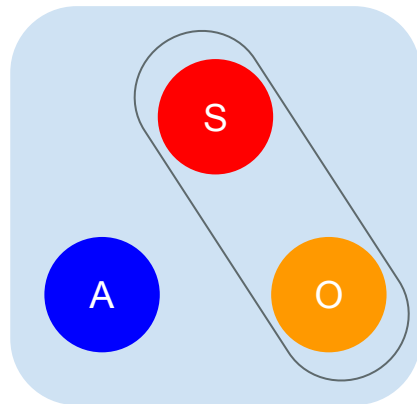
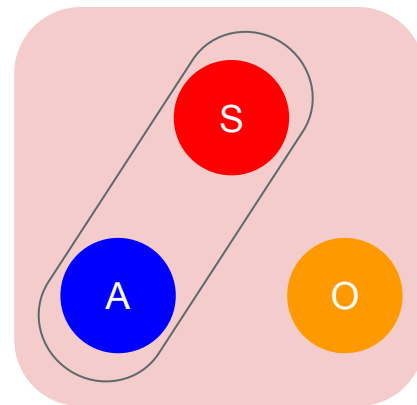
- Armenian, like many (but by no means all) Indo-European languages, shows **nominative–accusative alignment**
 - **Subject (S)** of an intransitive verb ~ **Agent (A)** of a transitive verb
 - **Object (O)** of a transitive verb
 - Engl.: “**Julia** runs.” – “**Julia** pets **the dog**.”
Ger.: “**Julia** rennt.” – “**Julia** streichelt **den Hund**.”
Lat.: “**Iulia** currit.” – “**Iulia** **canem** delenit.”
- **S** & **A** are treated identically (case, position, verb agreement, etc.), **O** differently.
 - “**Julia** pets **the dog**.” ≠ “**The dog** pets **Julia**.”
- **BUT**: it further exhibits something like **ergative–absolutive alignment** (also found in Hindi, varieties of Kurdish, Basque)
 - Here, in specific circumstances, **S** & **O** are treated identically, **A** differently

Morphosyntactic Alignment in Classical Armenian

- Synthetic tenses use **nominative-accusative** alignment
 - present, imperfect, aorist
 - **S=A** marked nominative
 - **O** marked accusative
- Analytical tenses use a different alignment
 - Perfect, pluperfect, (future perfect)
 - consist of participle and form of 'to be'
 - historically analysed as **ergative-absolutive**, **but...**
 - **S=O** marked as nominative/accusative
 - **A** marked as genitive

Problems:

- nominative does **not always equal** accusative
- historical models do not account for data

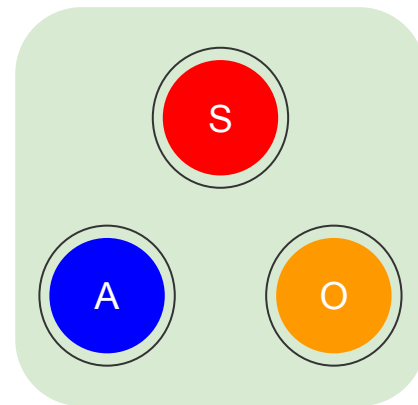


Complications in the perfect

- ○ is marked nominative/accusative – but **nominative** ≠ **accusative** everywhere
- ○ is often **differentiated for definiteness** – *the man* vs. *a man* (by proclisis)
- **Lack of verb agreement**: the finite form of ‘to be’ is invariable (when present)

Result

- ergative-absolutive alignment is a minority pattern / misanalysis
- more accurate: **tripartite alignment** (**S**≠**A**≠**O**)
- **tripartite alignment**: not economical, rarely stable, common sign of transition / change-in-progress



Examples & Observations

(1) tripartite alignment

oroy *yankarc* *uremn* *ēr* *gteal* *nšanagirs* *alp‘ap‘etac‘* *hayerēn* *lezui*
rel.gen.sg unexpectedly somewhere be.3sg.pst find.ptcp sign.acc.pl alphabet.gen.pl Armenian language.gen.sg
“... who unexpectedly somewhere had found the letters of the Armenian alphabet”

(2) quasi ergative-absolutive alignment

ew *nora* *tueal* *hraman* *ark‘ayagund* *banakac‘=n*
conj 3.gen.sg give.ptcp order.nom/acc.sg royal-guard army.dat.sg=det
“And he gave an order to the royal army.”

- next to the expected patterns, there are also two other minority patterns:
 - S marked genitive (type: nominative-accusative) – incidence falling across 5th century CE
 - A marked nominative (type: nominative-accusative) – incidence rising across 5th century CE
- system pressure from synthetic tenses – transitional pattern

Hypothesis: orig. ergative-absolutive > trans. tripartite > result: nominative-accusative

Replicating the past

(3) Parthian (ergative-absolutive)

qd tw 'br sd 'yy 'w=t 'z hyšt hym sywgy
when 2sg up ascend.ptcp be.2sg.prs conj=2sg.obl 1sg.dir leave.ptcp be.1sg.prs orphan
“When you ascended and left me an orphan...”

(4) Parthian (ergative-absolutive, no finite verb)

kw 'ym, cy=m 'c tw wx 'št, 'w mn w 'c 'h
comp dem rel=1sg.obl from 2sg request.ptcp to 1sg.obl say.2sg.sbjv
“... that which I requested from you, give it to me!”

Commonalities

- participle as pivot of construction
 - participle can function as adjective
 - use of the copula, but not in the 3sg
 - TSA – tense-sensitive alignment split (non-past vs past)
 - object case differentiation limited, use of object-marking proclitic
 - agent case also used for marking appurtenance, possession
- } pivot matching & polysemy copying

A superstrate shift

- historical and historiographical data point to the ‘death’ of Parthian in the region
 - no documents beyond the late 3rd century CE
 - identification with Armenians in opposition to other Iranians
 - Christianisation, wars against Sasanian Empire, intermarriage and tutelage together with Armenian nobles
- the Parthian rulers of Armenia adopted Armenian as their main language
- their variety was prestigious, their L2-idiosyncrasies were adopted by native speakers

Comparanda:

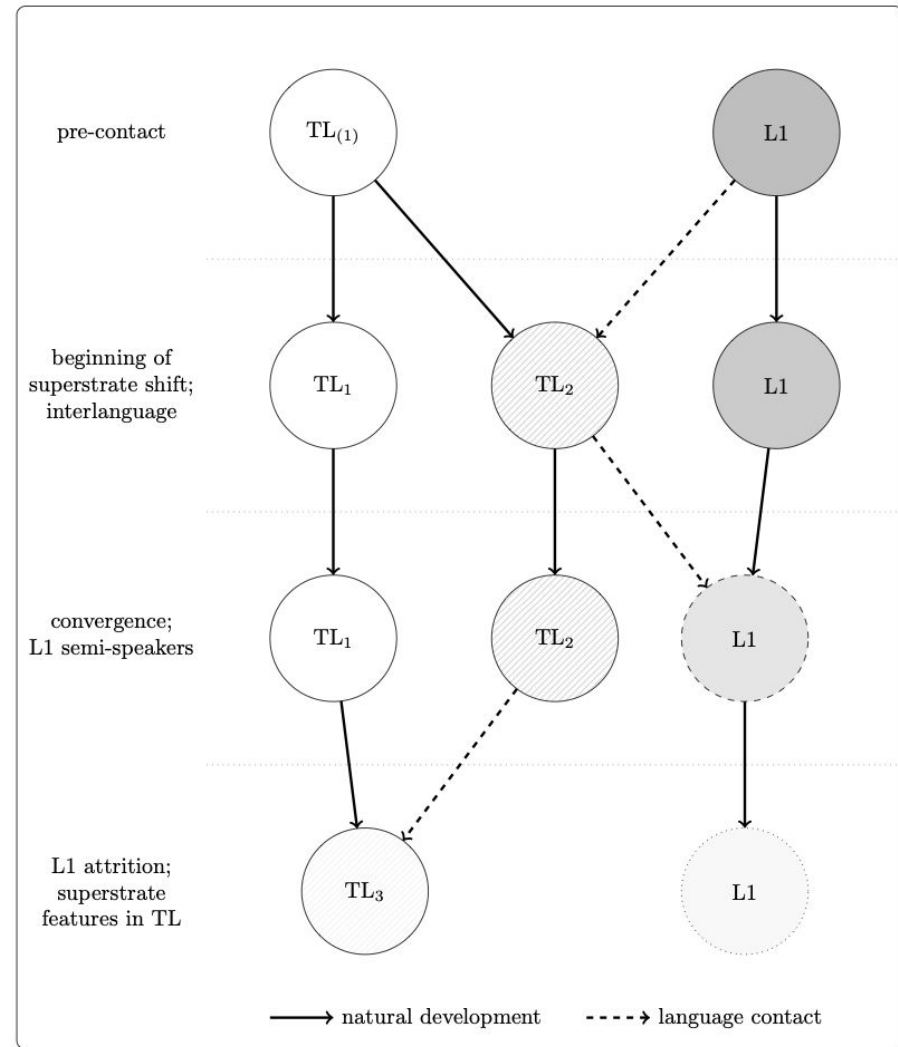
- Norman-French superstrate shift to English in the centuries after 1066 CE
- Similar replication processes in other languages in the Iranian periphery

Takeaways

- historical / corpus languages offer **limited data**, limited conclusions
- even the best analysis needs **extra-linguistic evidence** for support
- contact-based explanations may offer **new insights** where internal attempts have failed
- uncommon ≠ impossible** (e.g. superstrate shifts)

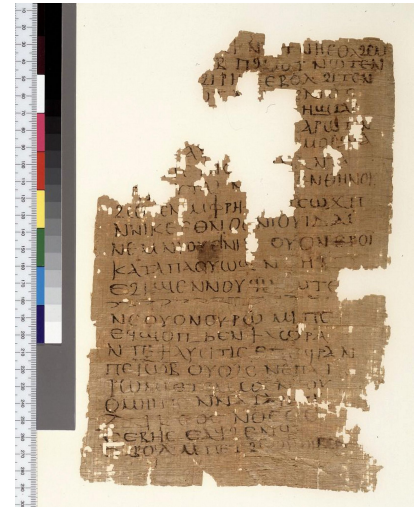
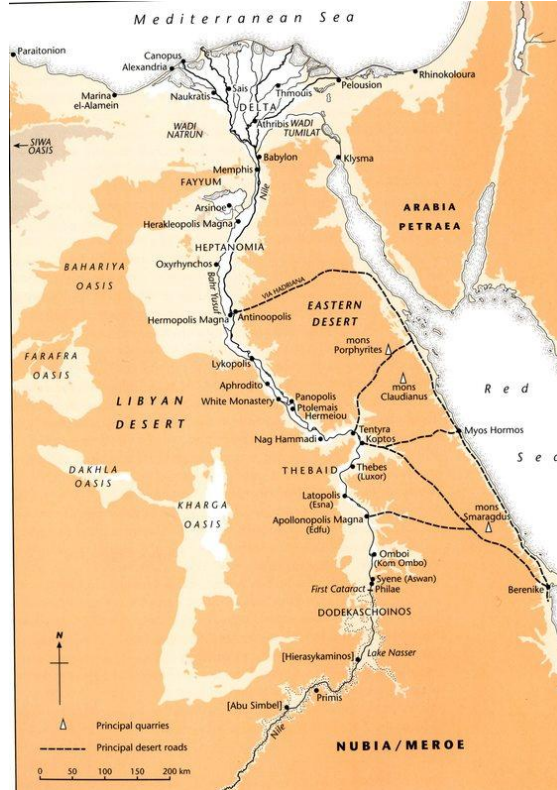
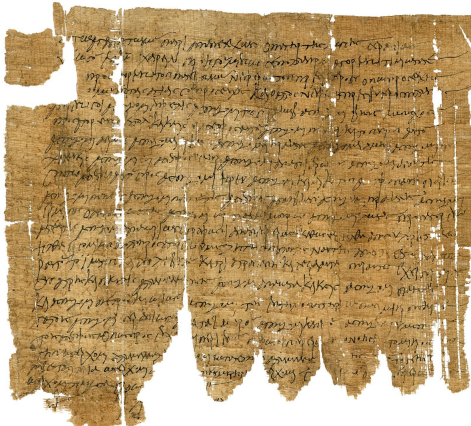
Iranian–Armenian contact explains:

- origin of perfect construction
- direction of its diachronic change
- lack of Parthian texts in the region



Bilingual interference & use patterns

Greek and Coptic in Egypt



Insubordination – definition

Insubordination = a structurally dependent clause comes to function as an independent clause (Beijering et al. 2019, Evans 2007)

Obwohl (.) ich komm doch besser bei dir vorbei

‘actually, I’d better come by your place’ (Günther 1996, 1999, 2000)

Oh **si** j’étais riche!

‘If only I was rich!’ (Patard 2014)

ὅτι

STANDARD

Εἶπε **ὅτι** ἦλθε / ἔλθοι (τότε)
'he said that he had come (then)'

- ὅτι → indirect statements / that-clauses after verbs of saying / reporting / etc. (van Emde Boas et al. 2019, §§41.4–15)
 - Adjustment of pronouns
 - Adjustment of deictic adverbs
 - Adjustment of verbal mood
 - Adjustment of personal ending of the verb

BUT:

Plato, Gorgias 452a ΣΩ. **Ὅτι** εἴ σοι αὐτίκα παρασταῖεν οἱ δημιουργοὶ τούτων ὧν ἐπήνεσεν ὁ τὸ σκολιὸν ποιήσας, ἰατρός τε καὶ παιδοτρίβης καὶ χρηματιστής, καὶ εἴποι πρῶτον μὲν ὁ ἰατρὸς **ὅτι** “**ὦ Σώκρατες, ἐξαπατᾷ σε Γοργίας**· οὐ γάρ ἐστιν ἡ τούτου τέχνη περὶ τὸ μέγιστον ἀγαθὸν τοῖς ἀνθρώποις, **ἀλλ’ ἡ ἐμή**” —**εἰ** οὖν αὐτὸν ἐγὼ ἐροίμην.

‘**In fact**, if suddenly the makers of these things, which the writer of the scholion praises, stood in front of you, the doctor, the trainer and the money-maker, and if the doctor said first: ‘Socrates, Gorgias is fooling you. For his art is not concerned with the greatest good for men, but mine (is).’ If I then asked him: (...)’

- ἵνα → purpose clauses / in order that clauses (van Emde Boas et al. 2019, §§45.1–4)
 - Adjustment of pronouns
 - Adjustment of deictic adverbs
 - Adjustment of verbal mood
 - Adjustment of personal ending of the verb
 - Usually following verbs of sending / achieving / etc.

BUT: P. Kell. Gr. 1 73.20–23

μὴ κατέχῃς τὸν υἱόν μου παρὰ σοί· ἵνα ἐλθῇς μετ’ αὐτοῦ πρὸς τὸν καιρὸν τοῦ γλεúčου.

‘Do not keep my son with you! **Go** with him at the time of the harvest!’

Insubordination – meanings and functions

- Ex. 1: Ger. *obwohl*

although vs actually

Obwohl (.) ich komm doch besser bei dir vorbei

‘actually, I’d better come by your place’ (Günther 1996, 1999, 2000)

Sie ist nicht vorbeigekommen, **obwohl** sie es versprochen hatte.

‘She did not come by **although** she promised to.’

- Ex. 2: Engl. if

condition vs wish

If only I knew how to explain this well!

I would explain this better **if** I knew how to.

- Ex. 3: Fr. *que*

morphosyntax vs discourse

Il est parti **qu’il** y avait quarante ans qu’il était chez moi

‘He left **when** it had been forty years that he was (staying) at mine’

Il a été habiter [sic!] à côté de chez Rosalie **que** Rosalie elle savait pas

‘He had been living next to Rosalie’s place, **but** Rosalie did not know’

(examples from Deulofeu 2008, pp. 32–33)

Changes

Domains of language usage = languages may be used in different domains (e.g. private, public, legal, economic, political) (Matras 2009)



→ Coptic was initially limited to private and more colloquial domains vis-a-vis Greek (Fournet 2009, 2019)

Top-down change = a feature spreads **from** the more literary and official domains **into** the more colloquial and private domains

Bottom-up change = a feature spreads **from** the more colloquial and private domains **into** the more literary and official domains

Parallels

Classical and postclassical literature

- ὅτι recitativum **already appears** in classical literature (e.g. Plato, Gorgias) and in the New Testament
- ἵνα as a wish/request/command particle **does not** exist in classical literature nor in the New Testament (cf. Blass et al. 1990, §483; van Emde Boas et al. 2019, §38.34)

Coptic

- **does not** have a morpho-syntactically marked differentiation between dependent and independent clauses
- **uses** ἕκασ *d'ekas* + future III in independent clauses YET makes a clear distinction between direct and indirect speech (Layton 2011)

Greek

- ὅπως with the future indicative **appears** in empathic exhortations / warnings in classical literature already (van Emde Boas et al. 2019, §38.34)

Use patterns

Use patterns = the distribution of (grammatical and idiomatic) features across genres, registers, speakers and texts

- Minor use patterns
- Major use patterns

Minor use patterns may become major use patterns under the influence of a second language (Heine & Kuteva 2005)

- Increase in frequency
- Extension to new contexts
- Assumption of new meanings

Takeaways



Ότι

- Exists in classical and postclassical literature
- Does not have a Coptic parallel

→ **top-down change**

Ίνα

- Does not exist in classical literature
- Has a Coptic parallel
- Appears primarily in non-literary non-official texts (Hult 1990)

→ **bottom-up change**

Spatial Evidence & Contact Effects

Why would it be hard to tell whether a change is the result of contact?

- this can be a hard question to answer especially in the case of **structural simplifications**
- there are two ways these *could* be the result of contact;
 - direct borrowing
 - or ‘simplification through imperfect second-language learning’ (Dahl 2001; Trudgill 2011; McWhorter 2011)
- but these are extremely ‘natural’ changes, so internal (i.e. spontaneous) change is also always possible

Then how *can* we tell whether contact is really the answer?

- contact between speakers of different languages is almost always concentrated in certain localities and certain groups in the population (cf. /r/ in Europe)
- so if we have enough evidence to see exactly where the changes started, we can check if the contact hypothesis fits: **did the change start where the contact was?**
- I'll be looking here at changes in medieval Norwegian which might have been caused by
 - intensive language contact with Low German through the Hanseatic League,
 - dialect contact with Danish,
 - or might have been internal change

Geography of southern Norway in the late medieval period

- largest cities are Bergen in the west, Oslo in the east; other large settlements include the cities Hamar, Stavanger and Trondheim, and the towns of Tønsberg and Skien
- centres of Low German contact are in red: Bergen has a Hansa *kontor* (trading post), and there are smaller Hansa presences in Tønsberg and Oslo



Loss of 1pl subject-verb agreement

	Old Norwegian		Middle Norwegian
1pl	-um		
1pl (verb-subject order)	-um / -u	→	-u
3pl	-u		

- This could be:
 - a **natural, internal development**, with the VS form spreading to other contexts and the *-um* form falling away, resulting in a simpler system
 - a **borrowed pattern** from Low German, which had just one ending in the plural (so 1pl=3pl)
 - the result of **intensive contact** with Low German, with adult second language learners failing to learn the different patterns in different word orders
 - a **borrowed pattern** from Danish, where a similar change had already happened
- We can test this with spatial evidence:
 - if due to contact with Danish, it should start in the cities (where there was the most Danish contact);
 - if due to contact with Low German, it should start in Bergen/Oslo/Tønsberg;
 - if an internal development, it could happen anywhere.

The data

- working with around 10.5k medieval charters (legal documents) mostly dated between 1300 and 1550 (Blaxter 2017)
- found (pretty much) all the 1pl verbs: 23,945 verbs in 5,747 documents

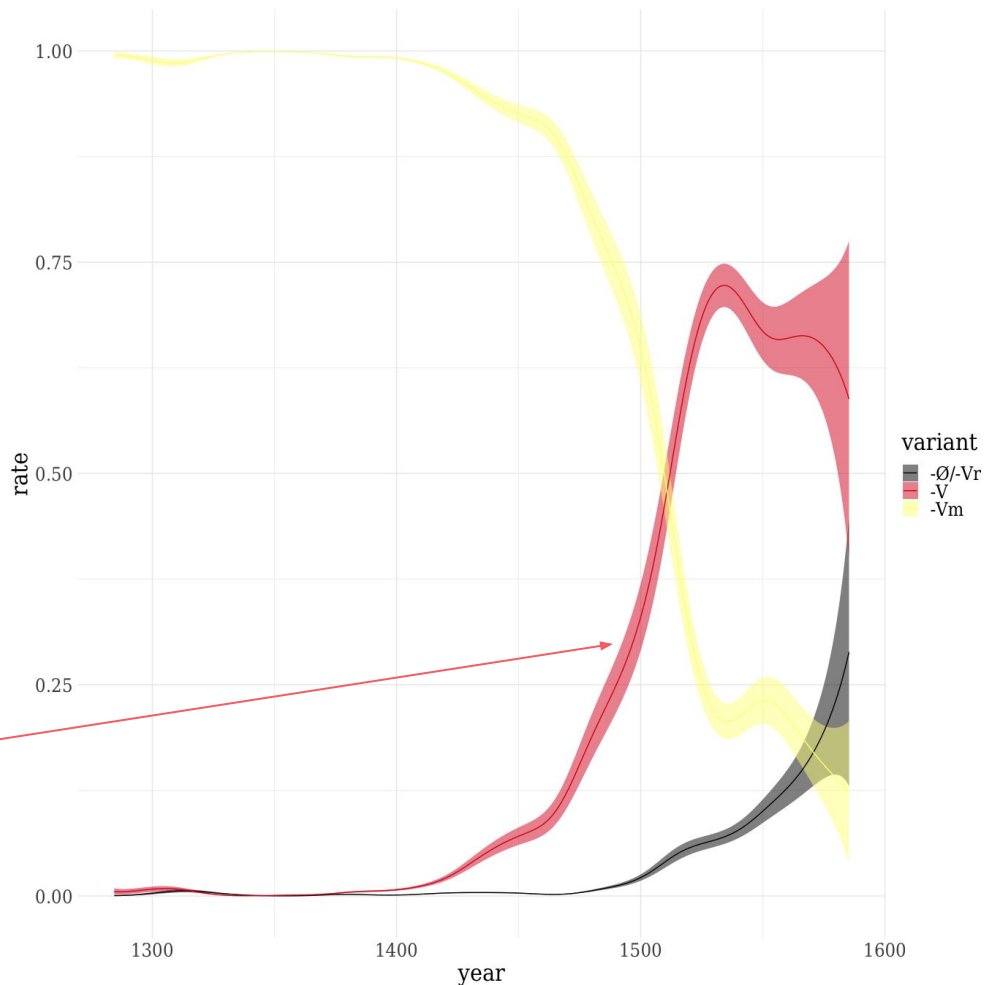


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fotografiet av Tor
Weidling,
Riksarkivet

The data

- looking here just at the subject-verb order examples, where Old Norwegian always has *-Vm*
- *-Vm* starts to decline in the early 15th c., and the most rapid part of the change is in the early 16th c.

This is our
change!



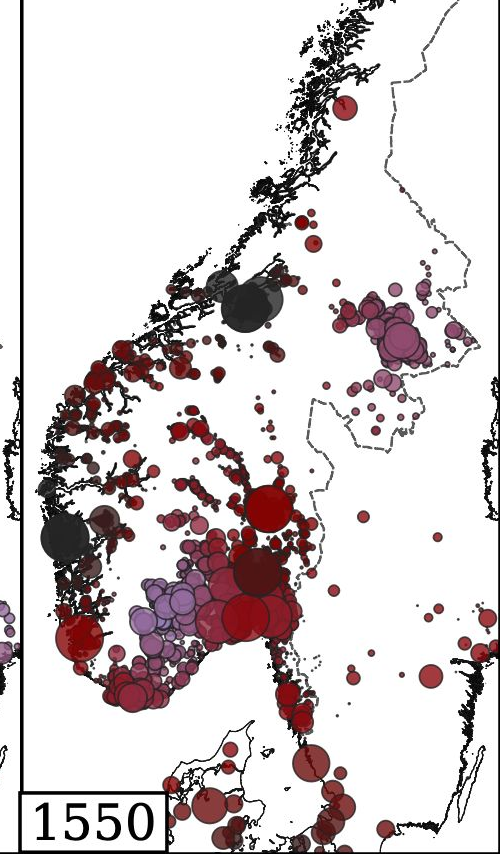
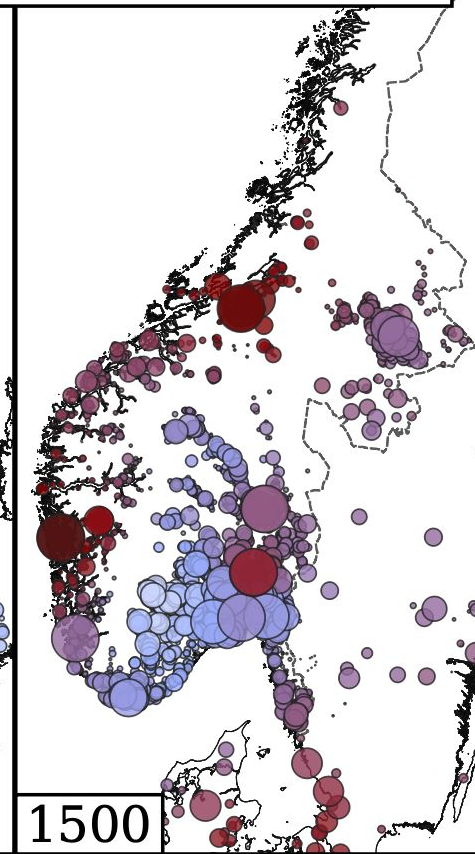
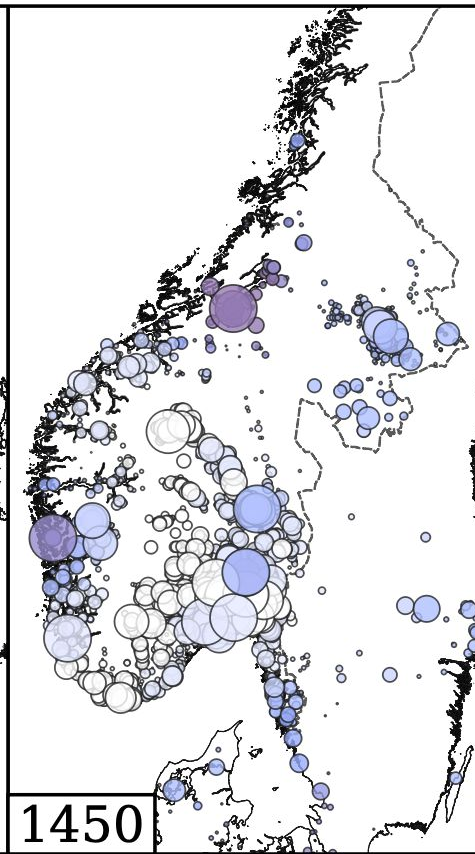
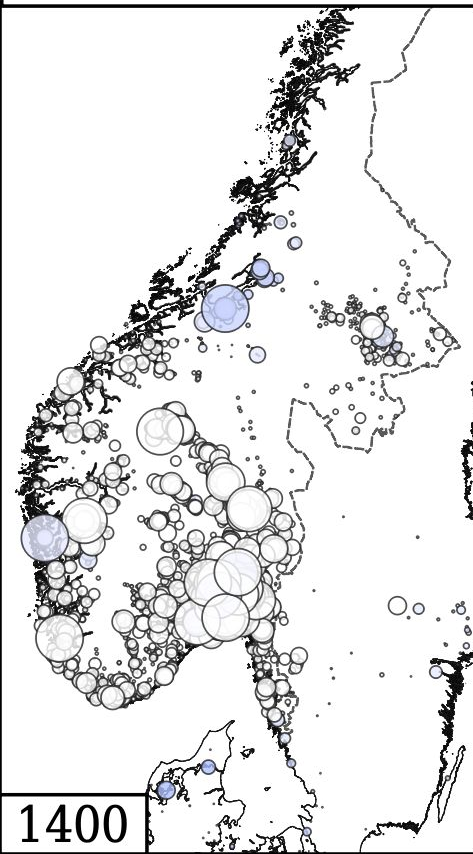
Note: writing the endings *-V* and *-Vm* here, because the way the vowels are written in texts is another complicated question!

The methods

(the technical bit)



- data are very **noisy**: we are probably wrong about where the texts are from so often that we can't see any spatial patterns just by looking at the data
- here using kernel smoothing with a static Gaussian kernel in time with a bandwidth of 28.92 years, and a Gaussian kernel in space with bandwidth adapting so as to ensure sample size always allows error margins of 10% with $\alpha=0.05$ (for more details: **Blaxter 2019**; **Blaxter forthcoming**)
- this gives us an impressionistic view of patterns across the whole map and across the whole period covered
- and also a metric of how large differences have to be for us to consider them real (20%)



The results

- **cities lead** this change: it arises **earliest in Bergen and Trondheim**, and then Bergen, Trondheim, Oslo and Hamar lead it throughout
→ this strongly points towards **Danish contact** as an explanation
- the leading positions of Oslo and Bergen *fit* the Low German contact explanation...
- ...but Trondheim and Hamar, which were not centres of contact with Hansa, also being leading locations *wouldn't* make sense if this were happening due to contact with Low German
- almost *any* distribution could be consistent with an internal development, but this 'hierarchy' pattern (no single obvious starting point, leading places are cities separated by rural areas which don't yet have the change) is much more suggestive of a change caused by some kind of contact with a mobile or distributed population

Takeaways

- it's often hard to distinguish between the effects of contact and internal developments, or between different types of contact, from linguistic facts alone
- but populations of speakers always live in particular places, have particular patterns of travel: so the geography of the effects of language contact will usually look different to the geography of internal developments
- here, this and many other simplificatory changes in medieval Scandinavian are generally seen as part of a big story of the effects of contact with Low German—so it's natural to assume that that must be true of each individual change...
- ...but these data are a lesson that we should try to avoid inferring from the big picture down to individual changes, and instead assess the evidence in each case!

The role of agency

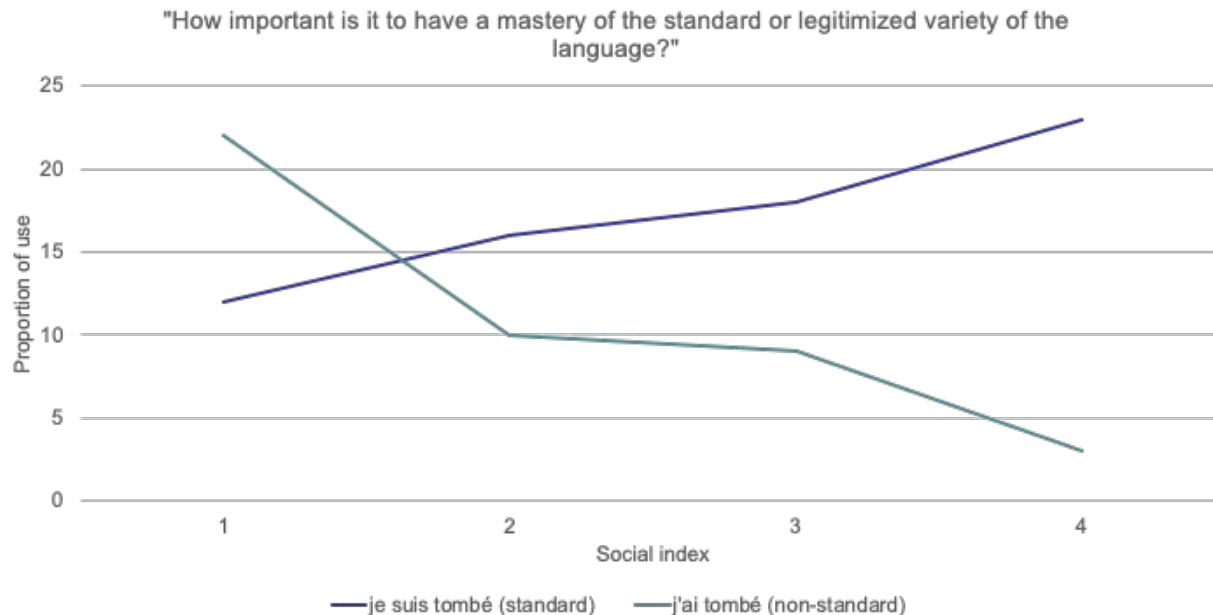
Sociolinguistic perspectives on language contact

- Sociolinguistics continues to debate whether **identity** is primary or secondary to linguistic change (Trudgill 2008, Babel 2010)
- There is consensus though that **language attitudes** can play a pivotal role in mediating e.g. which features win out over time
 - They can promote change
 - They can reverse/override/inhibit changes in progress
- “Language change may simply reflect changes in interlocutor frequencies which are in turn the result of changes in **social preferences and attitudes**” (Labov 2001: 191)

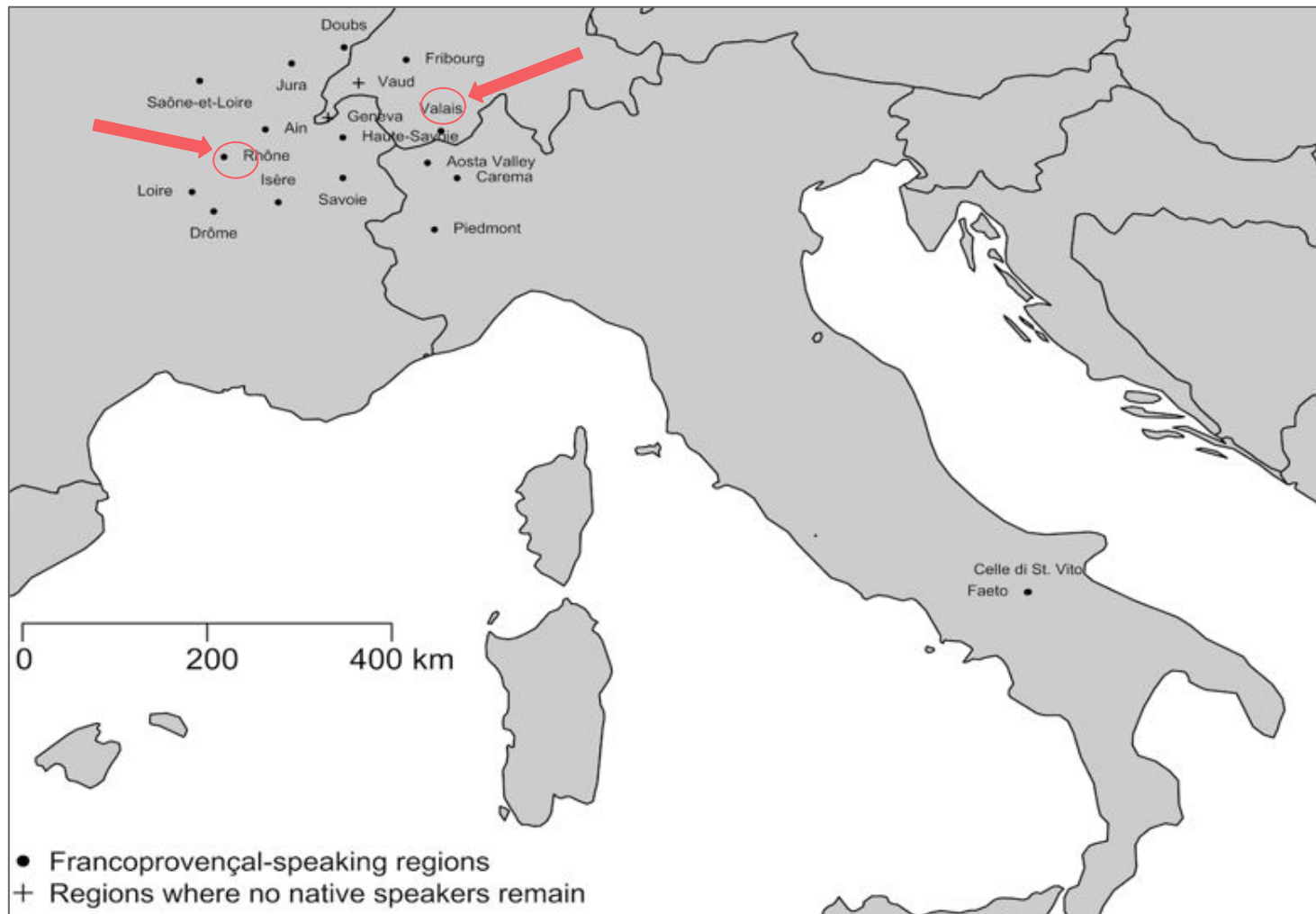
Sociolinguistic perspectives on language contact

- Outcomes of language contact cannot be fully understood without considering the fine details of “orderly heterogeneity” (Weinreich et al. 1968)
 - What is variable?
 - How is the variation linguistically constrained?
 - How is the variation embedded in social structures?
 - How do speakers evaluate the variation?
- Assessing how a feature is socially embedded requires understanding how communities evaluate variation.

An example of socially embedded variation



Rates of *avoir* and *être* with *tomber* per 1000 lines of transcription, and social factors in Montreal French



/l/-palatalization in Francoprovençal

- Palatalisation of L in CL, GL, BL, PL, FL sets: /kl, gl, bl, pl, fl/
 - **Linguists:** “In our dialects, the most widespread feature, under the most diverse and curious of aspects, is the palatalization of L in the velar + L and labial + L groups” (Durauffour 1932: 238; my translation)
 - **Speakers:** “famous L”; “impossible to explain to non-speakers” (my translations)

Attested variants (Stich 1998)

/kl/	[kl], [kʌ], [tj], [ʌ], [j], [çl], [çʌ], [ç], [tʃ], [θ], [ʈ]
/gl/	[gl], [gʌ], [ʌ], [j], [ð], [ʈ]
/pl/	[pl], [pʌ], [pj], [pθ], [pf]
/bl/	[bl], [bʌ], [bj], [bð], [bv]
/fl/	[fl], [fʌ], [çl], [çʌ], [ç], [θ], [ʈ]

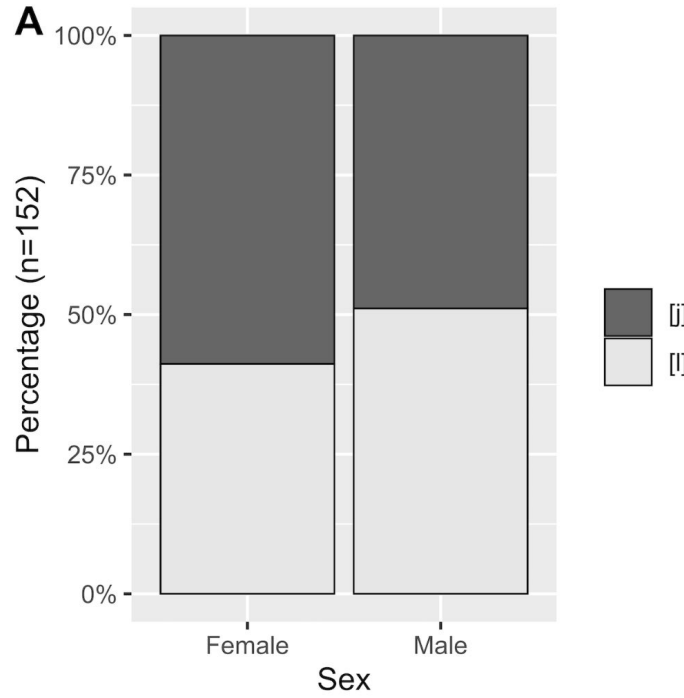
/l/-palatalization in Francoprovençal

- Not much sociolinguistic spadework
 - Lyon:
 - Linguistic atlases dating from early 1900s suggests the feature to be recessive (Gilliéron & Edmont 1902-1910, Gardette 1950-1956):
 - Early dialectology, evidences palatalization in **CL/GL clusters** only
 - Savèise:
 - Gilliéron (1880): palatalization is **categorical** in **CL/GL clusters** only;
 - Jeanjacquet (1932): palatalization is **variable** in **all clusters**, and “tending to disappear” by 1930s
 - Diémoz & Kristol (1994-2012) linguistic atlas, two participants (m,f), observe **variable** palatalization, for the male participant only

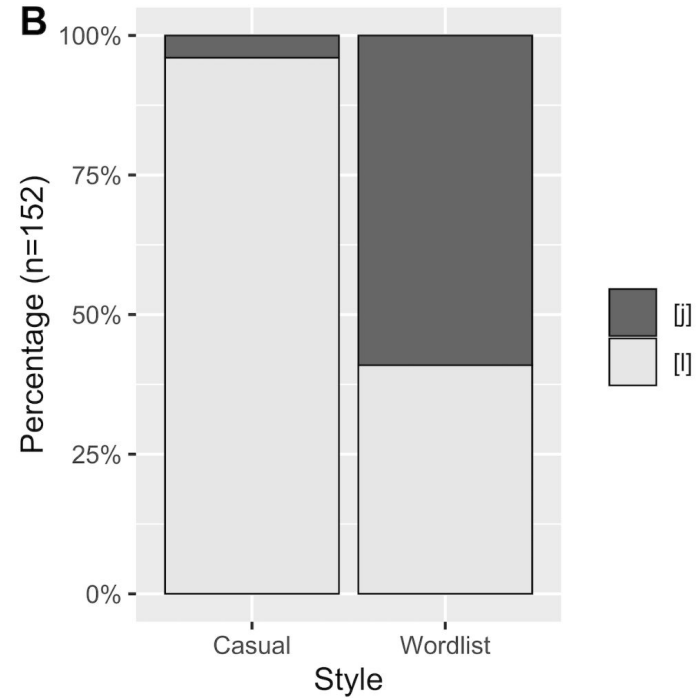
The methods

- **Speaker types**
 - Older (inter-war generation, sequential bilinguals, now French dominant)
 - Younger (post-war generation, acquired in late adolescence)
 - New (adult learners who acquire through revitalization strategies)
- **Sample**
 - Lyon
 - 16 older speakers (5f, 11m)
 - 2 younger speakers (2m)
 - 2 new speakers (3m)
 - Savièse
 - 12 older speakers (6f, 6m)
 - 2 younger speakers (1f, 1m)
 - 2 new speakers (1f, 1m)
- **Research design**
 - Quantitative sociolinguistics
 - Wordlist translation tasks (“formal”, more monitored speech)
 - Group interviews led by an older fluent speaker (“spontaneous”, more casual speech)
 - Ethnographic/sociolinguistic survey (language attitudes etc.)
 - n=833 tokens of (L) across both fieldwork sites

The results: (L) in Lyon

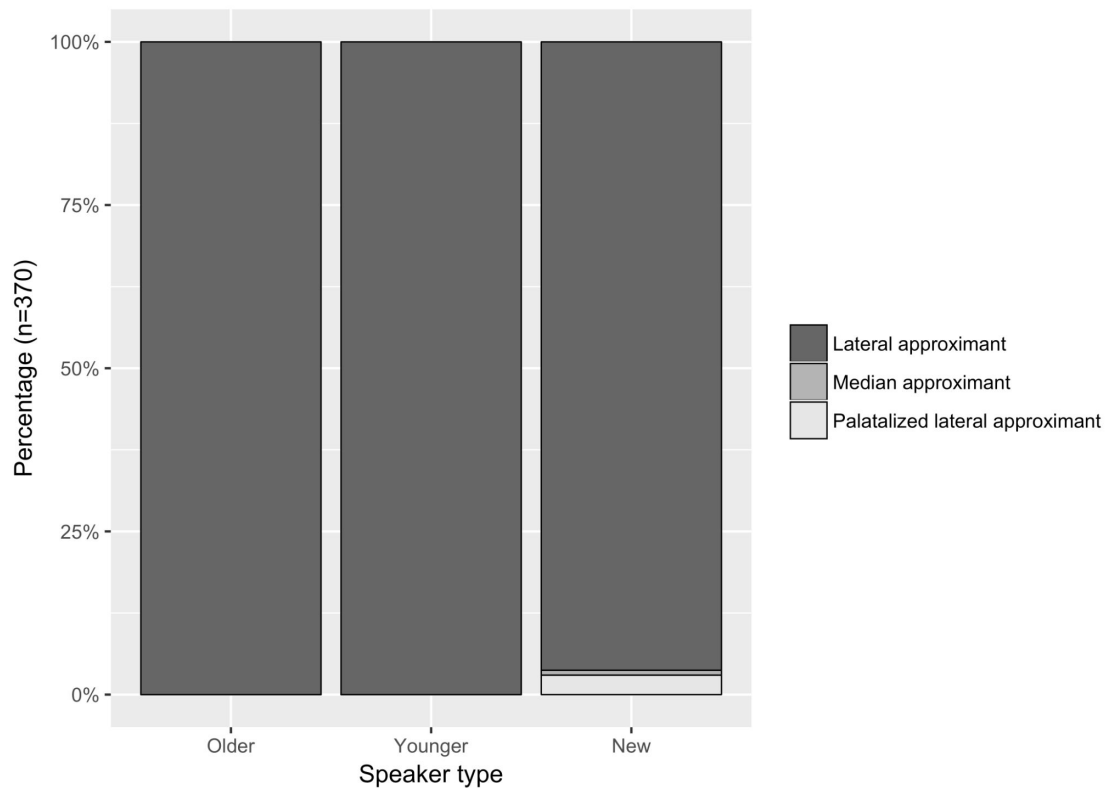


N.S., $p = 0.69$



Fisher's exact test, 2-tailed, $p < .001$

The results: (L) in Savièse



Takeaways

- Part of this story is about **contact**: an argument can be made for phonological levelling
 - Palatalization in **Savièse** first described as categorical, then as variable in the 1930s, but now fully de-palatalized
 - Change from a categorical rule to a variable one in **Lyon**
- But this variation is being **mediated by social** factors
 - Features that are strongly/positively evaluated might help them hold on
 - **Savièse**: introduction of palatalization in Savièse (marker of “local”, “authentic”)
 - **Lyon**: a once categorical rule has since become variable, giving rise to more strategic, agentive uses
- We must attune to **social** attitudes in order to understand **linguistic** behaviour
 - It is people, not merely dialects or languages, that are in contact (**Trudgill 1986**).

Summing up

Final takeaways

- language contact – and its effects — can be found **everywhere** and **at all times**, present, past, and future
- next to linguistic factors and evidence, **extralinguistic data** play a decisive role in determining **whether, how, and to what extent** contact took place and effect
- in the absence of a predictive model, we rely on comparative and typological data and each other – (contact) linguists need to **cooperate** and **communicate**

What to remember:

[In language contact] everything appears to be possible, although some things are improbable.

(Thomason 2003:695)

References

For a full list of references, click [[here](#)]

Thank you for listening!